

Original Article

A Case Study on the SWOC Analysis of Zomato in the Current Landscape

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Abstract: With the advent of the era of digitalization, there has been a multipronged enhancement in creativity and restructuring of various sectors, paving the way for the expansion of the digital economy globally. Additionally, the digital revolution has notably impacted the food service sector in India, as e-commerce has allowed consumers to place orders via mobile apps, with meals conveniently delivered to their doorsteps. Among the key players in this industry, Zomato stands out as a leading platform, offering an online food delivery service and helping users discover restaurants. This paper delves into Zomato's marketing mix, positioning strategies, competitive landscape, and SWOC (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Challenges) analysis. Based on the findings, the study highlights the need for Zomato to expand its services to remote regions and consider offering virtual restaurant tours to enhance the customer experience. Although the company's current positioning strategy is well crafted to capture market share, additional strategic initiatives are necessary to maintain a competitive edge in the dynamic market. Furthermore, the broader implications of Zomato's business model and its ongoing challenges in the evolving digital marketplace are also evaluated, thereby covering broad areas.

Keywords: Zomato, E-Commerce, Digitalization, Swoc Analysis.

I. INTRODUCTION

With the advent of globalization, there has been a steady rise in the usage of the internet, propelling the initiation, rise, and growth of multifaceted activities in the form of commerce and business, as well as an increase in communication between businesses and their customers. Globalization, broadly speaking, refers to the increasing interconnectedness of the economies, cultures, and inhabitants of the globe as a result of cross-border commerce in technology, commodities and services, and flows of information, capital, and people (Peterson Institute of International Economics, 2024, <https://www.piie.com/microsites/globalization/what-is-globalization>). With the rise in population need for employment to sustain livelihoods, there has been a steady migration from the rural areas to the urban metropolis, as a result of which there has been a steady inflow of population into the metro cities. Over time, with the increase in the accessibility to Internet facilities and the rise of e-commerce, there has been considerable progress in the functioning of online food delivery systems in the contemporary timeframe. As of 2019, i.e. even before the outbreak of the pandemic, the scale of India's online food distribution market was valued at around US\$ 3 billion, and the following year, it was valued at US\$ 4.35 billion, which reflected the signs of progress of the industry. Besides, in the food sector, online food aggregators (OFAs) provide a range of options and conveniences, allowing users to order meals from restaurants with a simple swipe on their smartphones (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021). Furthermore, the online food delivery services industry also forms a major component in supporting the informal sector and the nation's gig economy. Understanding the role of technology usage and the rise of food delivery platforms in forming the major component of the gig economy as well as the service sector, this paper mainly aims to undertake a SWOC Analysis of Zomato in the current landscape following a case study approach.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

Table 1. Prominent Literatures Reviewed

Author & Year	Objectives	Area/ Organization	Broad Findings
Mudgal & Rana, 2023	- To examine Zomato and Swiggy's development since its founding in order to identify the elements that aided in their success. - To research the communication tactics employed by Swiggy and	Swiggy & Zomato	On account of robust communication strategies incorporating innovative content that is shared by multiple users, Zomato stands out as a strong brand.



	Zomato to maintain a positive attitude among their target audience. To use a SWOT analysis to examine several facets of Zomato and Swiggy		- However, Swiggy does better when it comes to using user-convenience tactics. - Both organizations have been able to excel and outperform other competitors due to proper segmentation as well as positioning.
Hiray et al., 2022	- To gauge how satisfied users are with the Zomato meal delivery service. - To make pertinent recommendations on the aspects of e-service quality where users are not happy	Zomato	• Users of Zomato are happy with the interface and application design. Information on the portal that is current and correct, services that are provided as promised (reliability), and protection of financial and personal information. • The main reasons why customers are unhappy are Zomato's customer service and redressal policy, the necessity for strict measures against misbehaving delivery agents, and the refund and replacement of defective or missing goods.
Frederic and Bhat S., 2022	- To comprehend Swiggy's overview. - To talk about Swiggy's business strategy. - To enumerate Swiggy's top 10 rivals. - To explain Swiggy's marketing strategies. - To evaluate Swiggy's financial performance. - To use SWOT analysis to evaluate Swiggy.	Swiggy	- The key strengths of Swiggy include its efficient delivery services, its ordering interface, skilled personnel, and clean packaging, whereas the need for improvement in brand recognition and packaging cost are key weaknesses. - Swiggy has made significant progress in the competitive market since its inception and is one of the most valued OFDS in India.
Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021	- To recognize the different marketing mix tenets. - To examine Zomato's use of the marketing mix. - To investigate methods for improving marketing. - The SWOC framework will be used to examine the Zomato food delivery system.	Zomato	- The ease of use, utility, and advancement, along with trust and external influence, serve as the major factors affecting internet users. - The use of online food delivery services enables minimizing home cooking, thereby reducing the overall diet efficiency of the customer.
Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021	- To determine the different environmental elements influencing the online food market. - To examine Porter's Five Force Model's implications. - The analysis will be examined using the PESTLE Framework. - To develop a plan of action in areas where improving overall operating efficiency may be possible.	Online Food Service Industries	- With a rise in the inclination among people for digitization, there has been a rise in online food ordering as a popular business. - The rising population, growth of metro cities, longer travel times, the rise of ready-to-eat food culture, and less expensive alternatives of getting food delivered to the doorstep serve as the key factors propelling the growth of the online food industry.

Vishnupriya et al., 2020	- To analyze the purchasing pattern of fruits and vegetables by consumers at Raithara santhe - To find out the Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Challenges (SWOC) of Raithara santhe as perceived by the consumers	Yelahanka Raithara Santhe	- There exists a need for encouraging direct marketing among farmers to eliminate middlemen. - There exists a need for government interventions in the form of provision for shelters and information centre, encouraging online cycles in order to improve the functioning of the Sarithe.
Chauhan, 2019	- The goal is to recognize the marketing mix concepts. - To dissect Zomato's marketing strategy. - The goal is to investigate methods for improving advertising. - The SWOC analysis of the Zomato food delivery mechanism.	Zomato	- Zomato's reach continues to be limited in rural areas. - There exists a staunch need for Zomato to innovate by including virtual restaurant tours. - The company needs to be more adaptable to compete with the companies at the global level.

III. OBJECTIVE

- To understand the brief overview of Zomato.
- To analyze the marketing mix and undertake a SWOC Analysis of Zomato.

IV. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This study relies on secondary data, encompassing various textual sources used for data collection. The prominent secondary data sources include information from the Zomato website, academic journals, blogs, and other relevant company websites. Further, the focus is on analyzing Zomato's marketing practices, and suggestions are made to promote sustainable growth. This approach provides a comprehensive understanding of Zomato's business strategies while identifying areas for potential improvement in its marketing and growth efforts.

V. DISCUSSIONS

A) Companies and Firm

Post globalization and with the multipronged rise in the usage of technology across multiple dimensions, there has been a steady rise in e-commerce businesses, with Online food delivery systems occupying the lion's share. With the facilities of online food delivery, customers are now facilitated with multiple choices in the form of diverse cuisines, restaurants, timings and many more. The reasons for the success of both companies in the Indian landscape can be accredited to multiple factors in the form of penetration of internet facilities, strong online communication facilities, strong logistical base (Mudgal & Rana, 2023) and technological advancements. The following table represents the major online food delivery companies operating in India in the current time frame. In India, the major online food delivery players include Zomato and Swiggy.

Table 02. Major food delivery companies in India

Sl. No.	Company	Country of Origin	Year of Establishment
1.	Dominos Pizza	Ypsilanti, Michigan, US.	1961
2.	Zomato	Haryana, India	2008
3.	Food Panda	Berlin, Germany	2012
4.	Swiggy	Bangalore, India	2014
5.	Uber Eats	San Francisco, California, USA	2014

Source: Author's Own Construct

B) About Zomato

Zomato is a significant and major Indian multinational restaurant aggregator and food delivery company that was founded by Deepinder Goyal and Pankaj Chaddah in 2008. Initially, it functioned under the name 'Foodiebay', however, it was rebranded to Zomato in 2010. The initial days of the company were restricted to the national capital Delhi, but with due passage of time, it expanded its operations to multiple cities and countries. In the current landscape, Zomato operates in over 24 countries and more than 10,000 cities globally, not only connecting people with food but also collaborating closely with restaurants to foster a sustainable ecosystem.

Zomato's growth and operations are driven by a set of core principles that form the foundation of its organizational culture:

- **Resilience:** Zomato thrives in the face of adversity, consistently pushing beyond its capabilities. The company embraces adaptability and anticipates uncertainty, approaching challenges with a flexible mindset (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- **Acceptance:** Zomato values customer feedback, using it as constructive data to continuously improve its operations and service offerings, ensuring greater efficiency over time (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- **Ownership:** Zomato takes full responsibility for every issue, treating challenges as their own and driving meaningful change within the company (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- **Humbleness:** The company places a strong emphasis on teamwork, focusing on collective achievements rather than individual success. Zomato avoids arrogance and remains grounded, even during times of personal or corporate triumph (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021).
- **Spark:** The Zomato team embodies a spirit of belief and evangelism, advocating for their mission and fostering enthusiasm in their work (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021).
- **Judgment:** Zomato strives to make sound decisions in the majority of situations, aiming to consistently exercise good judgment in its operations and business choices (Chauhan, 2019).

This principles framework underpins Zomato's strategic direction, helping it navigate the complexities of the global food delivery market while maintaining a focus on long-term growth and sustainability.

C) Marketing strategies

Zomato was initially envisioned as a "Foodies' hangout" and has since evolved into a broader food network; according to a report by the Boston Consulting Group, the Indian food industry was valued at over ₹23 trillion in 2015 and was projected to grow to ₹42 lakh crore by 2020. Zomato has played a key role in reshaping the food service delivery experience, with technology serving as a major driver of this transformation.

a. Segmenting:

Zomato primarily targets the 18-35 age group, a demographic that enjoys dining out and seeks to be well-informed about restaurant options. Additionally, Zomato has identified professionals as a key segment—those who prefer dining out at work or having food delivered to their residences. In the experiential events sector, Zomato organizes entertainment and food festivals in various cities, such as 'Zealand'. Through these efforts, Zomato aims to provide customers with an enjoyable culinary experience by continuously developing food-centric products for both the dining-out and food-delivery segments (Mudgal & Rana, 2023; Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

b. Targeting:

Zomato focuses on attracting young consumers between the ages of 18 and 35, who often seek out opportunities to dine with friends and family. The platform aims to engage customers who actively provide reviews and feedback, as positive reviews can draw in additional customers by reinforcing perceptions of quality and value. Additionally, Zomato targets food enthusiasts who are eager to share their dining experiences and are always on the lookout for the best dishes in town (Mudgal & Rana, 2023; Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

c. Positioning:

Zomato has cemented itself as the favourite platform for young individuals with an urge to uncover new dining locations with family and friends. Its major attraction lies in the seamless experience it offers to those looking for information on restaurants, new food trends, and reviews, making it a popular choice among internet-savvy restaurant-goers (Mudgal & Rana, 2023; Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

D) Marketing Mix of Zomato

a. Product:

Zomato is a comprehensive app and website that offers users access to a wide range of restaurant information, including menus, prices, images, and customer reviews. It allows users to place orders online and serves as a platform for customers to share their thoughts on the cuisine and service quality of restaurants. Zomato's primary services include point-of-sale systems, restaurant expedition and delivery management, and advanced table booking options, all aimed at enhancing the overall dining experience (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

b. Cost:

Zomato does not charge restaurants to list their information on the platform. Instead, it generates revenue through restaurant advertisements, offering banner ads that increase visibility for restaurants on its website. Additionally, Zomato provides restaurant consulting services, advising chains on optimal locations for new outlets. The platform has also raised its Gold membership fees, introduced cross-selling during checkouts, and implemented phased delivery charges. Interestingly, lunch is the most commonly ordered meal online, and card payments are the preferred method. A significant portion of users

(95%) cited special deals and discounts as their primary reason for ordering food online, while 84% highlighted convenience and time-saving as key factors (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

c. Location/Place:

Zomato leverages mobile apps to allow users to place orders quickly and efficiently, contributing to the increasing use of smartphones for food delivery. It is available on Windows, Android, and iOS platforms and operates in 24 countries, including India, Australia, the United States, Chile, Malaysia, the UAE, Portugal, South Africa, and more. The user interface supports nine languages such as English, Italian, Spanish, Portuguese, and Turkish. Zomato is also active on social media platforms like Facebook, Twitter, Pinterest, and Instagram, where it engages with consumers. The evolution of logistics systems, particularly the growth of private courier services, has allowed Zomato to meet customer expectations regarding delivery speed and reliability (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

d. Promotion:

Zomato's advertising strategy is highly targeted, utilizing a built-in analytics platform to gather and disseminate valuable insights. The company is known for offering attractive deals, often surpassing those of its competitors. Zomato employs guerrilla marketing tactics and uses animations and eye-catching graphics to promote its services. One notable promotional event is Zomaland, a food festival featuring entertainment such as music, dance, and live performances. Zomato frequently offers discounts and promotional codes to entice customers and increase engagement (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

e. Physical Evidence:

As an online service, Zomato has no physical storefront. Its presence is mainly digital, with food being delivered by a team of third-party personnel. The company's delivery system is integral to its operations, facilitating the fulfillment of orders placed via the website or mobile app (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

f. People:

Zomato is powered by a strong team of over 5,000 employees, all dedicated to providing exceptional services to their clients. The trend of outsourcing non-core functions, such as food delivery, has gained popularity even among small businesses, which now recognize the importance of outsourcing delivery operations to improve efficiency (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

g. Process:

Zomato's process is streamlined for ease of use. Customers sign in using their registered phone numbers or email addresses, after which the platform tracks their geolocation and presents a list of nearby restaurants. Users can explore menus, place orders, and choose between cash or online payment methods. Once the order is placed, the restaurant approves and dispatches it. After delivery, Zomato solicits feedback from customers to improve the overall experience. Zomato's processes also reduce paper waste, as restaurants operate using tablet-based systems, digital menus, and automated order management, minimizing the need for printed materials and ensuring fast, accurate service (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

This seamless integration of technology and customer service has enabled Zomato to offer a convenient, user-friendly platform while maintaining operational efficiency.

E) What makes Zomato different from its competitors

a. Strategy:

To capture customer attention and encourage dining out, Zomato employs innovative strategies. Zomato Gold's premium membership program serves as a major example justifying the uniqueness of Zomato. It offers exclusive benefits such as Buy One, Get One (BOGO) deals and complimentary drinks, enhancing the overall dine-out experience. With over 600,000 customers, this program has successfully driven more foot traffic to partner restaurants, increasing customer engagement and loyalty. By incentivizing frequent dining experiences, Zomato strengthens its market presence while delivering value to its customers.

b. Brand:

To establish itself as a significant player in the competitive market, a company needs to have a strong brand identity, and Zomato has effectively built a brand that resonates with convenience, confidence, and accessibility. While competitors like Food Panda and Uber Eats have been present for some time, Zomato's focus on brand awareness and innovation has allowed it to maintain a dominant position. Through continuous modernization and a variety of marketing channels, Zomato has ensured the preservation and expansion of its brand equity.

c. Technology:

Zomato's competitive advantage is its investment in technology. The app's well-designed, user-friendly interface, combined with its visually appealing design, sets it apart from rivals. Zomato has placed great emphasis on creating a seamless experience for its users, ensuring that both its website and mobile applications load and function quickly, even for first-time users.

Besides the user interface of Zomato, heavy reliance on systematic data analytics has been instrumental in its long-term success. The company leverages data to gain major information in the form of operational and commercial insights, such as delivery time estimates, logistics optimization, and targeted advertising. This data-driven approach also helps Zomato improve its relationships with suppliers and streamline its operations.

Additionally, Zomato also aims to adopt the cloud kitchen model, which would serve as a strong foundation for scaling operations to a new domain with limited resources and lowered fixed costs. Furthermore, by laying emphasis on technological advancements, the company can remain the frontrunner in the food delivery industry with significant profitability.

Apart from that, in a market dotted with multiple new entrants, Zomato remains competitive by integrating with Google Maps for location data, customer reviews, and images. However, a key differentiator is Zomato's menu listing feature, which Google Maps has yet to implement. As a result, many customers rely on Zomato as their go-to platform for discovering restaurants, further boosting its value proposition as a comprehensive restaurant discovery and food delivery service.

F) SWOC analysis on Zomato

SWOC Analysis serves as the most widely acclaimed and accepted approach for monitoring and analyzing a company's overall competitive role. It emphasizes assessing options to create a corporate business strategy that aligns the organization's resources and capabilities with the demands of the world in which it operates. The analysis is mainly used by organizations to assess the company's competition as well as the product's strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and challenges. In other words, it can be stated that SWOC is mainly a detailed examination of the environment in which the company aims or tends to operate and guides the company in its crucial decision-making process.

➤ *Strengths*

The key strong points of Zomato include:

- a) As the company focuses mainly on food and restaurants, it is rated as a "Speciality Product" (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- b) Strong customer brand awareness (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- c) Significant global presence (25 countries, 1.5 million restaurant members) (Mudgal & Rana, 2023; Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- d) Advanced and up-to-date technology and a strong employable capacity (1200 workers) (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019)
- e) Simple and user-friendly UI (Mudgal & Rana, 2023; Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

➤ *Weaknesses*

The major highlighted weaknesses of Zomato include

- a) Competition in search engines, UI, and rivalry apps forecast limited growth for Zomato (Mudgal & Rana, 2023; Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- b) An acute deficit in the maintenance of food delivery standards among employees (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- c) Restricted service in rural regions is restricted (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- d) Probable chances of online fraud through misrepresentation as employees of Zomato, which encompasses multiple risks such as behavioural risks, product risks, psychological risks, financial risks, privacy risks, as well as seller efficiency hazards thus, there exists a staunch need for adequate government interventions (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- e) Absence of personal table service, lack of abilities to view or control multiple goods physically, and complexities involved over the processes of terms and conditions of food delivery and personal data sharing (credit card data) over the internet serve as major disadvantages (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- f) Prolonged usage of online meal delivery services may pave the way for a substantial reduction in home cooking, which further influences the overall diet efficiency of the client who is availing services from the company.

➤ *Opportunities*

The key breakthroughs available for Zomato that can pave the way for taking a giant leap forward are as follows:

- a) Exploring the chances of expanding into new nations (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- b) Inclusion of additional semi-urban and rural locations in the coverage maps (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- c) A rise in smartphone users due to a sustained increase in the rise in internet facilities can place multiple chances of tapping unexplored avenues (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- d) Systematic advancement of technology and the adoption of a simplified user interface can also add to the opportunities available in front of Zomato (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

➤ **Challenges**

In the ever-competitive world, the multiple set of challenges hindering Zomato are as follows

- a) Fierce rivalry amongst other food aggregators (such as Swiggy) (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- b) Protecting user information from online attacks (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- c) The absence of clear laws and restrictions by the government makes it easy for company models to adapt to shifts in governmental policies (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- d) The business model might be easily copied by other competitors, which would have a long-term detrimental effect on the organization (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- e) Because they have a wide range of options and no switching costs, online shoppers quickly move to competitors if they're not happy. As a result, all businesses using the internet have difficulties in retaining clients, which calls for more effort and strategies to increase customer satisfaction (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).
- f) To prevent customers from utilizing other delivery methods, online meal delivery services must ensure that the food is delivered to the client in an acceptable period of time and that the lead time is as low as feasible (Frederick & Parappagoudar, 2021; Chauhan, 2019).

➤ **Implications for management**

a) Limited Reach in Rural Areas:

Zomato's current reach is primarily focused on urban centers, limiting its expansion to rural areas. As more technological advancements open new routes, Zomato must capitalize on this opportunity through aggressive advertising campaigns targeting these underserved regions. By increasing its presence in rural areas, Zomato can tap into a wider customer base, potentially expanding its market share and addressing a growing demand for food delivery services in these areas.

b) False Reviews on the Platform:

The presence of false reviews on online platforms can mislead customers, potentially damaging the credibility of the service. To address this issue, Zomato could implement a reward-based verification system for reviews. By incentivizing users to submit honest, verified reviews through rewards (such as discounts or loyalty points), Zomato can enhance the authenticity of feedback and maintain trust among customers. This system would also foster transparency, ensuring that new users can rely on genuine reviews when making decisions.

c) Innovation through New Services:

Zomato must continue to innovate and differentiate itself in a highly competitive market. One potential service could be a virtual restaurant tour, which would allow customers to experience a restaurant's ambience before visiting. This could include live recordings and video shots from the restaurant, especially during events like live music performances or chef demonstrations. By showcasing popular aspects of the restaurant, such as unique dining experiences or signature dishes, Zomato can attract more customers and enhance user engagement. This innovation would also offer a more immersive and interactive platform for food lovers to explore and discover new dining options, further strengthening Zomato's brand as a leader in the food tech space.

VI. CONCLUSION

Given the strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities as well as challenges persisting before the organization, there exists a staunch need for facilitating a strategic evolution of digital marketing tactics of the company to maintain its competitiveness as well as sustenance in the contemporary landscape. Thus, it can be stated that to secure a competitive edge as well as sustenance in the era of competition earmarked with the rise of multiple organizations and competitors, the organizations must prioritize enhanced social management, customer retention, collaborations with influencers, increasing its reach to the unexplored areas, and laying a continuous emphasis on innovation and customer satisfaction.

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